Accessible Links

In short

People using screen readers often hear a list of links with no other words around them. Link text like ‘click here’ or a full web address doesn’t tell them where it goes. Write link text that says where the link takes you.

Note: Examples of poor link text in this section are shown without a link. The one example link outside the 'Useful links' section is just for demonstration, so you don't need to follow it.

What is it for?

Everyone has used links. Those wonderful bits of text can be selected to go to other pages.

Have you seen 'click here' links? A visual user will be able to set it in context and understand the place where the link will direct. But a person relying on assistive technology may scan links on the page, and they will be presented with a list of 'click here' links. They won't be able to understand where each link will direct them.

Sometimes people use the uniform resource locator (URL) as is, like this - https://inclusiontoolkit.org/accessibility/highlights/buttons. Visual users may not mind this too much, just scanning through it. However, a person relying on assistive technology will have to listen to the whole URL being read out to understand where the link will direct them. This can be disorientating as well as annoying.

How to support it

Link text should make it clear where the link takes you, even without any context. For instance, instead of showing the web address, the link could say the Buttons highlight in this toolkit. If it's in a sentence, make sure it makes sense, while also being clear where it goes to.

You should also avoid non-descriptive link text, like here, click here, read more, and more information.

Useful links

- Yale University - Links
- WebAIM - Links and Hypertext
- University of Reading: Accessible Links